SPACE AGENCY RACE

A COMPETITIVE STRATEGY CARD GAME

"We are running a space agency under pressure: engineering constraints, launch timing, and strategic trade-offs matter."

Players	Playtime	Age	Complexity
2 – 4	30 – 45 min	12 +	Medium

01

Welcome to Space Agency Race

In **Space Agency Race**, you lead a rival space agency competing for glory and government contracts. Design rockets from a shared pool of cards, accept daring missions, manage your credits, and launch craft toward the Moon, Mars, and beyond. The agency that banks the most **Victory Points (VP)** wins.

★ CORE FANTASY

Engineering trade-offs, careful planning, and bold decisions define your agency. Pick the right engine for the job, time your launches against your opponents, and decide whether to reuse reliable hardware or push experimental technology to score prestige missions.

CARD DRAFTING

Build your rocket from engines, tanks, payloads, and support gear.

ACTION SELECTION

Each round your Agency Level determines how many actions you control.

RESOURCE MANAGEMENT

Credits fund your operations. Missions are your primary source of income.

CARD SYNERGY

Technology upgrades and tag combinations reward long-term strategy.

02

Components

Card Types

Engine Cards

Supply **Thrust** to lift payloads from a planet. Engines may be Reusable, Disposable, or Stageable — each with its own trade-off of cost, reliability, and repeat-flight value.

Fuel Tank Cards

Provide **Range** — the distance your rocket can travel across the orbital map. Some tanks have special compatibility requirements (e.g., Cryogenic), while Stageable tanks can be jettisoned mid-flight for a one-time Range bonus.

Payload Cards

Satellites, probes, crew capsules, landers, and return capsules. Payloads come in three sizes — **L** (Light), **M** (Medium), **H** (Heavy) — and must be matched to an engine with sufficient Thrust. Satellites and Stations remain on the orbital board as persistent assets after delivery.

Support Cards

Heat shields, parachutes, and guided parafoils used for safe reentry and landing. A landing support card must be used when arriving at any Sub-Orbital node. Reusable versions return to your hand if the craft makes it back to Earth.

Mission Cards

Contracts that score VP and credits. Each mission specifies a destination, route, hardware requirements, and rewards. Missions come in three types — Public, Exclusive, and Secret — and three Tiers of difficulty.

Technology Cards

Permanent upgrades that improve reliability, reduce costs, or unlock new capabilities. Technologies are played to your Agency Tableau and remain active for the rest of the game.

Event Cards (Optional)

Global effects that last one round — funding boosts, solar storms, supply delays, and unexpected breakthroughs. Events add variety and are recommended after your first game. They can be removed for a fully deterministic experience.

Card Stats at a Glance

THRUST

Engine lifting power. Must meet the minimum for your payload size.

RANGE

Orbital steps a craft can travel. Spent 1 per node crossed.

PAYLOAD SIZE

L (Light) · **M** (Medium) · **H** (Heavy). Must match your engine's Thrust tier. Cards display the initial only.

RELIABILITY

Engine stat only (1–10). Represents hardware failure risk. Roll 1d10 once when your craft claims a mission — success if roll ≤ Engine Reliability + Tech bonuses − Event penalties.

VP

Victory Points awarded on mission completion.

COST

Credits required to acquire this card from the market.

In-Card Text Icons

Card rule text uses these inline badges instead of writing out keyword names in full:

VP Victory Points — scored on mission completion.

CR Credits (CR) — the game currency used to draft cards and pay costs.

Other Components

- **1 Orbital Board** — Combined VP track and orbital node map
- **VP Markers** (1 per player) — Tracked openly on the shared board
- **Credit Markers** (1 per player) — Tracked openly on each player's Credit track
- **Agency Level Markers** (1 per player) — Start at Level 1
- **Craft Markers** (6 per player) — Represent rockets and in-orbit assets on the board
- **1 First Player Token**

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Setup

01 Each player **chooses a color** and takes: 1 Starting Engine, 1 Basic Fuel Tank, 1 Starting Technology card, 5 Credits, 1 Credit marker, 1 VP marker (placed on 0), 1 Agency Level marker (set to Level 1), and 6 Craft markers.

02 **Sort Mission cards by Tier.** Shuffle the Tier 1 Mission stack and place it face-down as the Mission deck. Set Tier 2 and Tier 3 Missions aside face-down — they enter the game later.

03 **Reveal 3 Tier 1 Mission cards** face-up to form the starting Mission display.

04 Shuffle each of the remaining decks (Engines, Tanks, Payloads, Support, Technology, and Events if used) and place them in the card market area.

05 **Determine the first player** randomly. Give them the First Player token.

06 The game lasts **8 rounds**, or ends sooner if the Mission deck runs out.

EXAMPLE

SAMPLE STARTING SETUP — 3 PLAYERS

Each player holds: 1 Merlin-1a or Sterling Booster engine, 1 Standard Tank, 1 Precision Guidance tech card, and 5 Credits. The Mission

display shows *LEO Deployment*, *Emergency Resupply*, and *Capsule Recovery* — all Tier 1 contracts ready to accept on turn one.

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Round Structure

Each game round proceeds through four phases in order:

Phase 01
Planning
Draw cards up to your hand limit of 5. You may discard 1 card to gain 1 Credit.

Phase 02
Action
Players alternate Command Turns equal to their Agency Level. Each craft may be activated once per phase.

Phase 03
Launch & Resolution
All launched and activated craft resolve movement, mission checks, and reliability rolls.

Phase 04
Maintenance
Reusable returned parts go back to hand. Refill the Mission display. Ongoing effects expire.

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Actions

On your Command Turn, choose one action:

◆ Acquire Card
Pay the Cost shown on a card in the market. Add it to your hand.

◆ Sell Part
Discard a card from your hand and gain Credits equal to half its Cost, rounded down.

◆ Accept Mission
Commit to a Public mission in the display, or claim an Exclusive or Secret mission from the market.

◆ Assemble Rocket
Play Engine, Tank, Payload, and/or Support cards to your Launch Area. Any rocket launching from a planet needs an Engine.

◆ Develop Technology
Play a Technology card to your Agency Tableau for a permanent benefit.

◆ Launch New Craft
Place one assembled rocket onto the orbital board and advance it from its starting node.

◆ Activate Craft
Move one of your craft, satellites, or stations on the orbital board. Each craft may be activated only once per Action Phase.

◆ Expand Agency
Increase your Agency Level by paying Credits. Takes effect at the start of your next round.

Agency Levels

Expanding your agency unlocks additional Command Turns each round, letting you operate more craft and advance faster.

LEVEL 1	LEVEL 2	LEVEL 3
1 Command Turn	**2 Command Turns**	**3 Command Turns**
Starting level — no cost	Costs 6 Credits	Costs 14 Credits

⚠ MISSION TIER UNLOCKS

When the *first* agency reaches Level 2, immediately shuffle all **Tier 2 Missions** into the Mission deck.
When the *first* agency reaches Level 3, immediately shuffle all **Tier 3 Missions** into the Mission deck.
Each unlock happens only once per game. The player with the lowest VP gains a **Government Catch-Up Grant** at each unlock: **+3**

Credits at Tier 2, **+4 Credits** at Tier 3. If tied on VP, the tied player with fewest Credits gains the grant — or each tied player gains 2 Credits if still tied.

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Rocket Design

Assemble a rocket in your Launch Area from:

- **0–1 Engine** (required to launch from a planet)
- **1 Fuel Tank**
- **0–1 Payload**
- **0–2 Support Cards**

Lift & Thrust

Payload Size	Minimum Thrust Required
L Light	Any Engine (Thrust 1+)
M Medium	Thrust 5 or higher
H Heavy	Thrust 7 or higher

Fuel Tanks and Support cards are *not* counted as payload for lift checks — their mass is already reflected in their card values.

Staging

Cards with the Stageable tag can be jettisoned during a launch for a one-time Range bonus printed on the card. Staging happens after the lift check but before the Range check.

- You may stage **one** Stageable card per launch.
- A staged Engine still counts for lift and still counts as your Engine for that mission.
- Staging never changes Payload Size — only Range.
- A staged card is **discarded** after launch and cannot be recovered.

STAGING EXAMPLE

EXAMPLE

You assemble a **Kick Stage** (Thrust 7, Stageable) plus a Standard Tank (Range +5) and a Science Module (Heavy payload). After confirming Thrust 7 lifts the Heavy payload, you declare the Kick Stage staged: gain +2 Range (printed Stage bonus), giving a total Range of 7. The Kick Stage is discarded after the launch. The Science Module's mission still uses Thrust 7 for any maneuvering checks.

Example Rockets

ENGINE

Sterling Booster

Thrust 5 · Reliability 9

Disposable

Reliable

FUEL TANK

Standard Tank

Range +5

Stable

Range +5. Compatible with

PAYLOAD

Comm Satellite

Size: M

Satellite

Uncrewed

Remains on board as an

SUPPORT

Recovery Chutes

Parachute

Stageable

Thrust 5. High reliability, single-use.

most engines.

on-orbit asset after delivery.

Use from Sub-Orbital to land safely. Discard after

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Orbital Travel

Range is your rocket's travel budget — a simple representation of delta-v. Each line (edge) crossed on the orbital map costs **1 Range**. A craft moves **one node per activation** unless a card says otherwise. Return trips count the full out-and-back route.

Orbital Node Map

EARTH BRANCH

Earth → 1 → Sub-Orbital Earth → 1 → LEO → 1 → High Orbit

LUNAR BRANCH (branches from High Orbit)

High Orbit → 1 → Moon Transfer → 1 → Moon Orbit → 1 → Sub-Orbital Moon → 1 → Moon

MARS BRANCH (branches from High Orbit)

High Orbit → 1 → Solar Orbit → 1 → Mars Transfer → 1 → Mars Orbit → 1 → LMO → 1 → Sub-Orbital Mars →

Each arrow costs **1 Range**. Reverse the path for return trips — count every step back too.

Landing

Reaching a **Sub-Orbital** node is sufficient to land on that body. To do so, you must:

- Use a Heat Shield or Parachute card — discard it after use, or
- Perform a **propulsive landing** — spend 1 extra Range and use an Engine.

If your mission is a round trip, budget for **two separate** landing supports (one for each atmospheric entry).

Persistent Assets

Payloads with the Satellite or Station tag remain on the orbital board after a successful delivery mission. They use Craft markers and count toward your Agency's command total. You may activate them in future rounds like any other craft.

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Launch Resolution

During the Launch & Resolution phase, each launched or activated craft resolves in turn order:

1. **Check Lift.** Match your payload size to your engine's Thrust tier (see table in section 6). Craft without an Engine cannot launch from a planet; engine-free craft already in orbit may carry only a Light payload.
2. **Optional Staging.** Declare if you are staging one Stageable card. Gain its printed Range bonus. The staged card is discarded after launch.
3. **Check Mission Requirements.** Confirm the craft can reach Crewed, Docking). Missions tagged Docking or Maneuver require an Engine. In-Flight or On-Orbit may be attempted by legal

		the mission's required destination node given its total Range. Verify all required tags (e.g.,		Missions tagged	engine-free craft already in space.
4	**Move the Craft.**	Advance the craft along the orbital map, spending 1 Range per node crossed. Each activation moves the craft one node unless a card says otherwise.			
5	**Roll for Reliability.**	Once your craft reaches its mission destination, roll 1d10 once. If the roll is equal to or less than the Effective Reliability, the mission claim succeeds.	**Effective Reliability = your Engine's Reliability + Technology bonuses − any active Event penalties.**	Only the Engine contributes a base value. This roll is made once per mission attempt — craft already in space do not re-roll on subsequent activations.	
6	**Resolve the Outcome.**	On a *success*: score the listed VP and Credits immediately. On a *minor failure* (roll slightly above Reliability threshold): reduced or no reward, components remain. On a *major failure* (roll well above threshold): one or more components are lost or discarded.			

Recovery

- If a craft returns to the **Earth** node, all unstaged Reusable parts return to your hand during Maintenance.
- Staged parts are *always* lost — reusability does not apply to them.
- Non-Reusable parts are discarded unless another card effect says otherwise.
- If a craft *remains in space*, all its parts stay attached to the craft.

EXAMPLE

FULL LAUNCH EXAMPLE

You assemble a **Hydrogen Core** (Thrust 8, Cryogenic) + **Cryo Tank** (Range +8) + **Science Module** (Heavy) and accept the *Deep Space Probe* mission (requires Range 16+).

Range check: 8 is less than 16 — you need more range. So you also play a **Long-Range Tank** (Range +10), giving 18 total. You stage the Cryo Tank (Stage: +2 Range), discarding it for +2 extra Range this launch, bringing total to 20. Heavy payload needs Thrust 7+ — Thrust 8 clears that. Mission requirements are met. Roll 1d10: you roll 4 against effective Reliability of 7. Success! Gain **15 VP + 6 Credits**. The Long-Range Tank (non-Reusable) is discarded; the Hydrogen Core (Reusable) returns to hand when the craft reaches Earth.

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Missions

Mission cards are your agency's contract system. Each card shows a destination, required route, hardware requirements, and rewards.

Mission Types

Public Missions

Remain in the Mission display after players commit to them. Multiple agencies can race to complete the same Public mission. The card

leaves the display only when completed.

Exclusive Missions

Leave the display the moment they are claimed. Belong to one player only. No other agency may attempt them.

Secret Missions

Kept face-down in your play area. Must be revealed *when completed* to score. May be gained at setup or through card effects.

Mission Tiers

Tier	Unlocks When	Mission Focus
Tier 1	Available from the start	Earth orbit, sub-orbital returns, LEO deployments
Tier 2	First agency reaches Level 2	Lunar missions, orbital assets, science relays
Tier 3	First agency reaches Level 3	Crewed flights, Mars missions, deep space probes, full returns

Mission Market Rules

- Empty slots in the Mission display are refilled during Maintenance.
- When a mission is completed, score its rewards immediately, then discard it.
- Secret missions are revealed face-up only when scored.

Sample Mission Cards

MISSION · T1

LEO Deployment

Range 5 · Reward: 3 VP + 2 ¢

Public · LEO

Requires: Uncrewed payload.

MISSION · T2

Lunar Landing

Range 10 · Reward: 8 VP + 3 ¢

Public · Surface

Requires: Lander + Range 10.

MISSION · T3

Mars Orbit Insertion

Range 14 · Reward: 12 VP + 5 ¢

Public · DeepSpace

Requires: Range 14+, Medium or larger payload.

MISSION · T1

Capsule Recovery

Range 1 · Reward: 5 VP + 1 ¢

In-Flight · Public

Requires: Light payload + Heat Shield or Parachute.

Technology

Technology cards are permanent upgrades played to your Agency Tableau. Once active, they apply to every applicable launch and check for the rest of the game. Technologies can reduce costs, increase Reliability, or enable new strategies such as treating your payload as one size lighter for mission requirements.

EXAMPLE TECHNOLOGIES

- **Reusable Refurb** — Reduce engine repair costs; reusable engines gain +1 Reliability.
- **Cryo Handling** — Use Cryogenic tanks without compatibility penalties; +1 Reliability for cryo setups.
- **Precision Guidance** — +1 effective Reliability on all launch checks.
- **Modular Payloads** — Treat your payload as one size lighter for mission requirements (e.g., Heavy counts as Medium).

Scoring & End Game

The game ends after **8 rounds**, or sooner when the Mission deck is depleted. After the final round, all players tally their total VP from:

- Missions completed during the game
- Technologies that award end-game VP
- Any bonuses from persistent orbital assets

The player with the **highest VP total wins**.

⚖ TIEBREAKERS

1. Most remaining Credits
2. Most successful launches completed

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Complete Example Turn

EXAMPLE

ROUND 3 — AGENCY "STARBOUND" (LEVEL 2)

Planning Phase: Starbound draws up to 5 cards and picks up a Cryo Tank and an Imaging Probe.

Action Phase — Command Turn 1: Pay 5 Credits to acquire the Hydrogen Core engine from the market (Thrust 8, Cryogenic). It goes to hand.

Action Phase — Command Turn 2: Assemble a rocket in the Launch Area: Hydrogen Core + Cryo Tank (Range +8) + Imaging Probe (Light payload) + Heat Shield (landing support). Accept the *Lunar Landing* mission (Range 10, requires Lander — wait, Imaging Probe isn't a Lander, so this crew pivots). Instead accept *Lunar Flyby* (Range 8, Scientific payload required ✓).

Launch & Resolution Phase: Thrust 8 easily lifts the Light Imaging Probe. Range total = 8. Declare launch toward Moon Orbit (High Orbit → Moon Transfer → Moon Orbit = 2 steps from High Orbit; Earth → Sub-Orbital → LEO → High Orbit → Moon Transfer → Moon Orbit = 5 steps total). Range needed: 5. Range available: 8. Checks pass. Roll 1d10 against Reliability 7 — roll a 3. **Success!** Score 5 VP and draw a Tech card. Imaging Probe reaches Moon Orbit.

Maintenance Phase: Starbound recovers the Hydrogen Core (Reusable) back to hand, since the craft returned to Earth. The Cryo Tank (non-Reusable) is discarded. The Mission display is refilled with a new Tier 1 card.

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Card Tags

Tags on cards create connections between hardware requirements and mission conditions. A card with a tag contributes that capability to the craft or effect that needs it.

Reusable Returns to hand when craft reaches Earth (if not staged). **Disposable** Discarded after launch; never returns to hand.

Stageable Can be jettisoned for a printed bonus Range. **Cryogenic** Requires compatible engine; higher Range at the cost of reliability.

Experimental Higher risk, potentially higher reward; lower base Reliability. **Crewed** Enables crewed missions; requires life-support consideration.

Satellite Remains on orbital board after delivery as a persistent asset. **Station** Like Satellite, but larger; enables docking missions.

Heat Shield Required for atmospheric reentry at Sub-Orbital nodes. **Parachute** Alternative to Heat Shield for atmospheric landing.

Docking Mission requires a craft with an Engine to dock at a Station. **Maneuver** Mission requires orbital maneuvering; Engine mandatory.

In-Flight Mission may be completed by a craft already in flight (no Engine needed).

On-Orbit Mission may be completed by a craft currently in orbit (no Engine needed). **Surface** Mission requires landing on a planetary or lunar surface.

Scientific Payload carries scientific instruments; gates certain mission requirements.

Glossary

Term	Definition
Agency Level	Your operation scale (1–3). Determines how many Command Turns you take each Action Phase.
Command Turn	One action taken during the Action Phase. You take one at a time, alternating with other players.
Craft	Any assembled rocket, satellite, or station on the orbital board. Each may be activated once per Action Phase.
Credits	The game's currency. Earned mainly by completing missions. Used to acquire cards and expand your agency.
Government Catch-Up Grant	Bonus Credits awarded to the trailing player when a new Mission Tier unlocks.
Mission Display	The face-up row of available Mission cards. Refilled from the Mission deck during Maintenance.
Orbital Board	The shared board showing the VP track and orbital node map where craft are placed and moved.
Payload Size	Light, Medium, or Heavy — must be matched by an engine with enough Thrust to lift it.
Range	Orbital travel budget. Each node crossed costs 1 Range. Represents delta-v in simplified form.
Reliability	Engine stat only (1–10). Represents hardware failure risk. Roll 1d10 once when claiming a mission; success if roll ≤ Engine Reliability + Tech bonuses − Event penalties.
Staging	Jettisoning a Stageable card during launch for a one-time Range bonus; the card is then lost.
Thrust	Engine lift power. Must meet the minimum threshold for your payload size.
VP (Victory Points)	The main scoring currency. Earned from missions, Technologies, and bonuses. Tallied at game end.

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